

Arsenal FC: History from 1990 to 2026

A concise overview of Arsenal Football Club's journey from the George Graham era through Arsene Wenger's revolution, the Emirates transition years, and the Mikel Arteta rebuild culminating in the 2025/26 Premier League title.

1990–1995: George Graham and Defensive Dominance

Arsenal entered the 1990s as one of England's strongest sides. The club won the 1990/91 First Division title, losing only one league match all season. Graham's teams became famous for defensive organization built around Tony Adams, Steve Bould, Nigel Winterburn and Lee Dixon. Arsenal also won domestic cups and the 1994 European Cup Winners' Cup, the club's first major European trophy.

1996–2004: The Arsene Wenger Revolution

Arsene Wenger arrived in 1996 and transformed English football through modern training methods, nutrition, sports science and international scouting. Arsenal won league and FA Cup doubles in 1997/98 and 2001/02. The peak came in 2003/04 when the 'Invincibles' completed an unbeaten Premier League season, one of the greatest achievements in football history. Key figures included Thierry Henry, Dennis Bergkamp, Patrick Vieira, Robert Pires and Sol Campbell.

2005–2013: Emirates Transition

Arsenal moved from Highbury to the Emirates Stadium in 2006. The new stadium strengthened long-term finances but restricted spending during the early years. Wenger maintained Champions League qualification while developing players such as Cesc Fabregas, Robin van Persie, Samir Nasri and Jack Wilshere. Although trophies became scarce, Arsenal remained a consistent top-four side.

2014–2018: Final Wenger Years

Arsenal ended a long trophy drought by winning the FA Cup in 2014 and followed it with additional FA Cup wins in 2015 and 2017. However, the club increasingly struggled to compete with the financial power of rivals such as Manchester City and Chelsea. Wenger departed in 2018 after more than two decades in charge.

2018–2019: Unai Emery Era

Unai Emery replaced Wenger and guided Arsenal to a fifth-place finish and the Europa League final in 2018/19. Despite moments of promise, defensive inconsistency and instability prevented a full return to elite status.

2019–2022: Early Arteta Rebuild

Former Arsenal captain Mikel Arteta became manager in December 2019. Arsenal won the 2020 FA Cup but also experienced consecutive eighth-place league finishes. Arteta undertook a major squad rebuild, focusing on youth, culture and long-term identity. Players such as Bukayo Saka, Martin Odegaard and Gabriel Martinelli became central figures.

2022–2025: Return to Title Contention

Arsenal re-emerged as a Premier League force. The club finished second multiple times while pushing Manchester City in intense title races. Declan Rice, William Saliba and other key additions helped create one of the league's best defensive units. Arsenal also re-established themselves in the Champions League.

2025/26: Champions Again

After years of rebuilding, Arsenal won the Premier League for the first time since 2004. Arteta's side combined defensive strength, tactical maturity and squad depth. The team also reached the UEFA Champions League final, confirming Arsenal's return to the highest level of European football.

Key Timeline

1990/91 – League champions under George Graham. 1994 – Won European Cup Winners' Cup. 1996 – Arsene Wenger appointed. 1997/98 – Premier League and FA Cup Double. 2001/02 – Premier League and FA Cup Double. 2003/04 – Invincibles season. 2006 – Move to Emirates Stadium. 2014 – Ended trophy drought with FA Cup victory. 2018 – Wenger leaves Arsenal. 2019 – Mikel Arteta appointed manager. 2020 – FA Cup winners under Arteta. 2022–2025 – Consecutive title challenges. 2025/26 – Premier League champions.